

Racing Wisely

Athletes frequently ask me about how many races they will need as they get set to start the journey toward their goal event. Particularly if their goal is challenging, athletes often feel the need to have some logical series of races in order to prepare. The question has always puzzled me. No one really “needs” a race. Yet many people think there is some magical formula that will tell them, “If you complete x and y races, you will be prepared for your goal.”

Further confounding the issue is the fact that the number of ultrarunning events grows every year. It is quite easy to find a 50K, 50-mile, or 100-mile event on any given weekend. In certain areas, the travel required to reach an ultramarathon is minimal. Given that most ultrarunners are an outdoorsy group, George Mallory’s oft-quoted rationale “because it’s there” becomes a reason to race and race often.

Doing a race because you feel you “need” it or simply because “it’s there” is a poor way to pick and choose events. Unfortunately, many athletes fall victim to this psychology. They endlessly chase the races they feel they need because they are there. They race too much, and they race without true purpose.

Statistics on ultrarunners tease this out as well. A greater percentage of ultrarunners run more than one race per year compared to their marathon, half marathon, 10K, and 5K counterparts. This is particularly interesting because the effort and recovery required for an ultra are far greater than for sub-ultra distances.

To better understand what racing means to each individual, I gathered several of my athletes on a conference call. Some of them race nearly every weekend. Others race only once in a calendar year. The conversation was fascinating. Interestingly, while the optimum quantity and types of races varied wildly from athlete to athlete, their viewpoints on why and when to race were equally dissimilar. What ultimately emerged was a different set of values each athlete placed on the racing process. That value system then set the construct for how many and what types of races each athlete did.

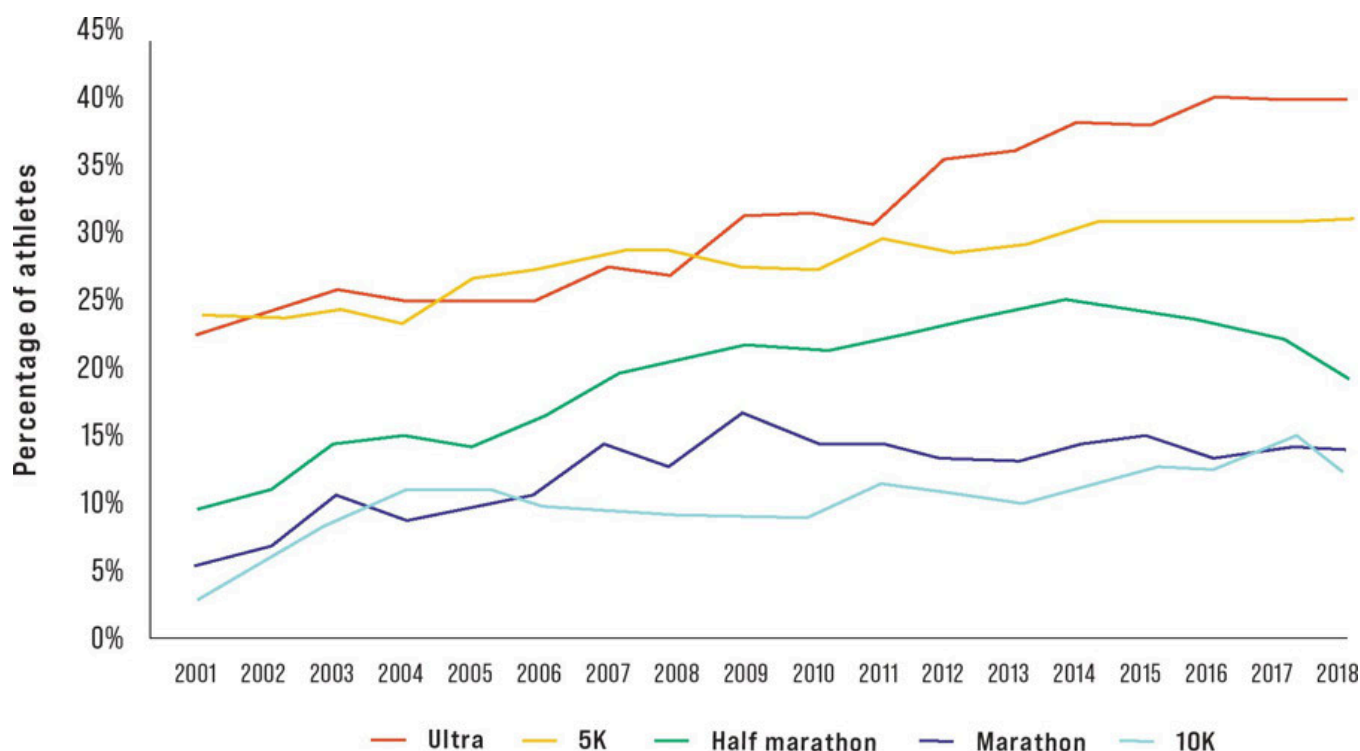


FIGURE 17.1 Percentage of racers competing in multiple races per year. Adapted from Andersen 2020.

Racing and what it represents to you are rooted in your personal values. The values you put on the process of racing should determine what and when you choose (not need) to race. Like many other value systems, this one is entirely individual. The same series of races that works for one athlete might be counterproductive for another, even when they are preparing for the same goal event.

In the following sections, I have summarized the racing values for the various athletes I work with. Some might fit your own value set; some might not. Your values will ultimately determine what races you pick and how many of them end up on your calendar. I encourage you to use these as a starting point for your goals. The ultimate end point is up to you to craft.

Racing as the End of Means

For many, racing represents the simple end point of training. While from a coaching standpoint I always view training as continuous, some athletes bookend the process with the races they choose. Athletes put in miles, contrive different intervals, and sacrifice time with family and friends to make themselves better in order to race at their best. For these athletes, racing fulfills the training process. In some cases, much of the athletes' specific training is spent hammering up steep gravel roads. Many times, this is at the expense of climbing some breathtaking peak, rock climbing, or reading (yet another) book. For these athletes, racing validates the work and sacrifice necessary to achieve their goals. Racing is the ultimate point of what they do on a day-to-day basis. If you are an athlete who sees racing as the logical end point of a period of training or preparation, you may not feel the need to race very frequently. You are more likely to place greater value on particular races that are important to you, rather than racing for the sake of racing.

Racing as a Competitive Outlet

Many of us are competitive by nature, and this innate competitive psychology drives athletes to want to race. Running against fellow athletes or against oneself is what racing represents. These athletes enjoy seeing how their fitness and toughness stack up. When your competitive drive is what you're satisfying, it may make sense to incorporate more high-quality racing into your annual plan.

Racing as Part of the Training Process

Day-to-day training can only prepare you for so much. Managing aid stations, drop bags, foreign terrain, and event-day logistics is difficult to replicate in training. Racing can help to bridge the gaps that remain. Furthermore, racing can provide an opportunity for a big training stimulus. The duration and intensity of the race usually exceed what an athlete can accomplish in day-to-day training.

Some athletes place a similar value on the racing process. They race a lot, sometimes three out of four weeks a month throughout many months of the year. They race frequently because they value racing as part of the training process. I know this because I interact with athletes like this on a daily basis, and together we determine how much emphasis to place on different races throughout the year. This assessment is crucial for any athlete who is

using races as part of the training process. There is only so much physical and emotional bandwidth available for racing. Determining each race's individual emphasis helps to manage that bandwidth.

For many athletes, races can help bridge the gaps between day-to-day training and the goal event. Sometimes they provide a great opportunity to put in a huge training day with aid station support rather than having to manage that support on your own. They provide a bigger training stimulus and an arena for athletes to work on the things they are going to face during their goal event.

Racing to Be Part of a Community

I often say that "it's the same group of idiots at every race." For many, racing involves community. In ultrarunning, we are lucky that the community is such a good one. The "idiots" I lovingly refer to are friends I have had the fortune of sharing the trails with on many Saturdays. Many ultrarunners find that racing allows them to touch base with the community of people they identify with, much like any other social group. This is why you see many ultrarunners become aid station volunteers and attend races simply to cheer other people on. They value the community of people who make up the sport. If it's the community that draws you to races, but you struggle with balancing your purposeful training with the preparation for and recovery from frequent races, you may benefit from volunteering at events. That way you can stay engaged with the community while still staying true to your overall long-range plan for the year.

Find Your Racing Values

The answer to the question "How many races do I need?" comes from first determining your racing values. The aforementioned examples are just a few. Racing can represent many things to you, and these can ebb and flow over time. When setting up your season and choosing races, first think about what those races represent to you. Is it the competition, a stepping-stone, the end point of your training, or something entirely different? Like any value system, your racing values are for you to determine. After you have done this, the distance, timing, and frequency of the races you choose can follow suit.

Optimal Racing for Maximum Performance

If your race values are rooted in achieving optimal performance, there is a range of race frequency that you can utilize to ensure that you are toeing the line in the best shape possible. For purposes of simplification, the following ranges assume that you are racing only at the specified distances in a twelve-month period. For example, if you want to maximize your performance at the 100-mile distance, you can do so one or two times per year if that is the only distance you race.

- 100-MILE: one or two times per twelve months
- 100K AND 50-MILE: two or three times per twelve months
- 50K: three or four times per twelve months

Is Suboptimal Racing OK?

Yes! You can race four 100-milers in a calendar year (or in a few short months, as is the case with the Grand Slam of Ultrarunning). But that does not mean you can optimally prepare for each one. How suboptimal is the third, fourth, or fifth 100-mile race in a twelve-month period? That's a guessing game, and the answer is rooted in your own personal physiology and psychology. The point is, if your racing values are to optimize the training process, you will be most likely to fulfill those values by limiting your racing. This does not mean that racing more is bad (suboptimal $\neq$ bad). It only means that when you are determining your racing values, it is important to keep in mind the practical ramifications and possible drawbacks of choosing too many races.

Prerequisite Training Distances for Ultramarathons

One of the persistent concepts in run training is that you must be able to complete a specific percentage of your goal distance in training in order to be prepared for your race. This idea comes from marathon training, where people are convinced they need to complete a twenty-mile run as the final long run before their taper. But there is nothing magical about that twenty-mile run, and there is similarly nothing magical about running 50 miles before you attempt to run 100, or 30 miles before you attempt to run 100K. Ironically, this is one area in which marathon training is similar to ultramarathon training: the one long run is not a prerequisite for success.

Would it be ideal if you could do it? Sure. Completing very long runs helps to reinforce your pacing, nutrition, and hydration strategies. Very long runs give you the opportunity to face adversity and work through rough patches. But the physiology necessary to successfully complete an ultramarathon is not significantly impacted by whether or not you have completed one single very long run. If you cannot incorporate such a run into your training schedule, but you can focus on developing your cardiovascular system and creating the strategies to manage your effort level and fueling, you can still successfully complete an ultramarathon.

KEY POINTS FOR HOW MUCH TO RACE

There are no prerequisite races necessary to be successful at any ultramarathon distance.

Finding your racing values will help you determine how many races you want to do.

You can race as the end of means, as a competitive outlet, as part of the training process, or to be part of the community.

If you are looking to race optimally, limit your racing to one to two times per twelve months for a 100-miler, two to three times per twelve months for the 100K or 50-mile distance, and three to four times per twelve months for the 50K distance.

Suboptimal racing is OK as long as you identify the goals of the race during the training process



